

## **HUMAN RELATIONS SCHOOL**

While the classical approaches focused on the structure and the formal organisation, the human relations school approach focused on the social factors of work and the behaviour of employees within the organisation.

### **2.1. The Hawthorne Experiments**

The most famous works under this approach was the Hawthorne experiments of Elton Mayo at the Western Electric Company in USA (1924 -32). The four main phases of the Hawthorne experiments were as follows:

- The illumination experiment
- The relay assembly test room
- The interviewing programme
- The bank wiring observation room

#### **i. The illumination Experiments**

The experiment was initially testing the validity of the classical approach using the scientific management style with the effects of the intensity of light on workers' productivity. The workers were divided into two groups thus the experimental group and the control group. There was no conclusion on this experiment on the possible relationship between the level of lighting and productivity. In some cases, productivity improved when the conditions were made much worse. This simply means that the level of production was influenced by factors outside the physical conditions of work.

#### **ii. The relay assembly test room**

In the relay assembly test room, the work was boring and repetitive. A team was created that had a mixer of friends and in some cases merely co-workers. The researchers divided the experiment into 13 periods during which the workers were subjected to a series of planned and controlled changes to their conditions of work, such as hours of work, rest pauses and provision of

refreshments.

During the experiments, the observer adopted a friendly approach, consulting with the workers, listening to their complaints and keeping them informed of the experiment. There was a general increase in production. The researchers concluded that extra attention given to the workers and the apparent interest in them shown by management was the main reason for higher productivity.

### **iii. The interviewing programme**

The preceding phases of the experiment drew attention to the effect of supervision on worker's productivity. Under this phase, the research sought to establish the feelings of workers towards their supervisors and the general conditions of work through a large interviewing programme. Initially the interviewers formulated a structured questionnaire focused on the views of workers on their jobs. The questionnaires produced limited information and the workers talked about other issues other than supervision and immediate working conditions.

The style of interviewing was changed with and introduced more non-directive and open-ended questions. The interviewers set out to be friendly and sympathetic and adopted an impartial, non-judgmental approach and concentrated on listening. This approach produced some very valuable information of the workers' views on supervision, working conditions, company itself, management, work group relations and matters outside the work such as family life and views on society. Many workers welcomed the opportunity of having someone to talk to about their feelings and problems. This experiment led to an impetus to the development of the human resource management and use of counselling interviews and the need for management to listen to the worker's feelings and problems. Being a good listener is still very important in today's management thinking.

### **iv. The bank wiring observation room**

This experiment involved the observation of 14 men

working in the bank wiring room. The results revealed that men tended to form informal working groups, with subgroups or cliques with natural leaders emerging with the consent of other members. The group formed its own social relationships with group norms of what constituted a proper behaviour. The group controlled output levels despite the availability of financial incentives for more output. The group pressure on individual workers was stronger than the management financial incentives.

## **2.2 Evaluation of the Human Relations School**

This approach has been subjected to severe criticism as follows:

- a. The Hawthorne experiments have been criticised on their methodology, and on the failure of the investigators to take sufficient account of environmental factors.
- b. The human relations advocates were criticised for the adoption of a management perspective, their unitary frame of reference and their oversimplified theories.
- c. It was insufficiently scientific, took a narrow view and ignored the role of the organisation itself in how society operated.

## **2.3 Importance of the Hawthorne Experiment**

- a. They did develop new ideas concerning the importance of work groups and leadership, communications, output restrictions, motivation and job design.
- b. They placed emphasis on the importance of personnel management and gave impetus to the work of the human relations writers.
- c. They undoubtedly marked a significant step forward in providing a further insight into human behaviour at work and the development of management thinking.